

NIKHIL TIWARI

TIME CAN GRIND DOWN EVEN THE STRONGEST. Olympic medallists Bajrang Punia and Sakshi Malik and Asian Games gold medallist Vinesh Phogat might have trained to be fighters nearly all their lives but, on May 30, standing on the banks of the Ganga at Har ki Pauri in Haridwar, for the first time, the fight went out of them. Shielded by a human chain of family members and friends, they wept, clutching a bounty of hard-earned medals—two Olympic, six World Championship and four Asian Games between the three—their "life and soul", as they called them.

They intended to immerse them in the holy river. Only two days ago, they had been pulled off the streets of New Delhi, manhandled by Delhi Police and now had FIRs lodged against them for assaulting women police officers. "How did this happen?" Vinesh, who was world No.1 in her category in 2021, was heard asking repeatedly at Haridwar. The 28-year-old couldn't fathom how a protest to bring sexual harassment charges against Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, who is also the BJP MP from Kaiserganj, Uttar Pradesh, had ended with charges of assault against her.

This was one bout that they had severely underestimated. For the past six months, they had lost not just the support of much of their family and friends, but also crucial training time and fitness—the next Asiad, due later this year in the Chinese city of Hangzhou, seems too distant a milestone now, as does the World Championship in Belgrade. They have newly known hostility from sections of an Indian public that had only lavished them with adulation till now. Professional contracts have gone abegging. Most of all, what they have found slipping away from them, in a way they have never known, is the strength to keep going. Their struggle comes at a time when female participation across sporting disciplines is growing—India fielded its largest female contingent at the Tokyo Olympics recently with 56 athletes, while the recently concluded Khelo India University Games had 1,715 girls competing. This makes their lonely crusade nothing less than a defining moment for Indian sportswomen, one whose outcome will determine how federations and governments deal with cases of sexual harassment in sports. In a significant victory after a long-drawn battle (see *A Long Journey*), Delhi Police filed a chargesheet against Singh and WFI assistant secretary Vinod Tomar on June 15.